

So you're ready now—a little basic knowledge goes a long way. You want to speed things up, you want to make XP more intuitive to your personal way of doing things, you want to make it look pretty and impress your *khandhan* and friends...

But needless to say (at least now, after a dozen warnings!), delving into the Registry is not for the careless or faint of heart. The first and last rule when hacking XP's innards is to *back up* before doing anything. Ideally, keep a little notebook with you. Note down the changes you're making and the backup file prior to the change. This will help you quickly roll back to an earlier backup if things should go wrong.

A few general rules: if you make a change, it is best to reboot. If you are going to make a bunch of changes, do them all at one go and reboot. In most cases, you shouldn't face any problems. If you do, roll back to the last backup and go through the list again one by one between each reboot, until you reach the offensive hack. Sometimes you will need to re-create the String / DWORD / Binary values under a key, or even the key itself.

If a setting does not work as discussed, or, even worse, does the opposite of what was intended, reset it to the previous setting.

4.1 Performance

Eking the last bit of performance out of your XP machine is what this section is all about. Here's a list of some of favourite performance hacks.

Load Applications Faster

The Windows prefetcher aims to load applications faster by “pre-fetching” the application and storing it in the pre-fetch cache. You can speed up application loading by changing the default value of one the settings under the relevant key.